

Bridging Gaps in Human Capital

The concept of human capital—centered on education, skills, and labor market experience—remains crucial for productivity and welfare. However, policymakers now face new challenges: persistent gender wage gaps, rising wage inequality, and shortages of qualified public sector workers. The TSE Human Capital Center at the Toulouse School of Economics addresses these issues by uniting over 20 researchers across five themes: Education Policies, Gender and Labor Markets, The Future of Work, Human Capital in Developing Countries, and Income Shocks.

The proposal is structured around three key actors: individuals, firms, and the public sector. For individuals, the focus is on gender disparities in career progression. Projects include randomized experiments in Germany targeting gendered educational choices, estimating wage dynamics using French data, and analyzing gendered language in academia and media using AI tools. For firms, research explores how they drive wage inequality and respond to large-scale education reforms. A Chilean case study examines general equilibrium effects of college expansions, while another uses Mexican data to analyze the role of informal firms in wage setting. For the public sector, the focus is on attracting and retaining qualified teachers. Using Peruvian recruitment data, one study evaluates hiring practices and teacher effectiveness; another in Norway examines how career uncertainty affects teacher attrition, suggesting reforms for flexible career paths.

Led by TSE Professor Matteo Bobba and six core faculty members of the TSE Human Capital Center, the team combines expertise in labor economics, development, econometrics, and behavioral economics. By combining state-of-the-art empirical methods with a rich set of large-scale administrative and survey data, the project is well positioned to generate insights that can inform public policies aimed at fostering more equitable societies.